

Count Fast and Slow Losers				
				Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

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Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥

Declarer: East

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 5
♥ 3
♦ K 10 9 2
♣ 7 6 5 4 2

♠ A K Q J

♥ 7 4 2

♦ J 8 6 4

♣ K Q

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 9 6 3
♥ A 10 9 8
♦ A Q 5
♣ J 10 9

♠ 7 4 2

♥ K Q J 6 5

♦ 7 3

♣ A 8 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			
4♥ by North			

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♥.

Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner tells you that he has enough points to be in game, and that he holds exactly 5 ♥s. With your 3 ♥s you know of an 8-card Major fit so you correct the contract to 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣J. You win the opening lead with your ♣Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The 2 ♦ losers are unavoidable, and even you will have to give up a trick to the Ace of trumps. So you have to make sure not to lose a second ♥.

Win the ♣Q and play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥J, which holds the trick.

I hope you didn't continue drawing trumps by playing the ♥K. If you did then you are going down in an ice-cold contract.

The way to lose only one ♥ trick is to keep leading toward dummy's honors. So come to your hand with a black card and play another ♥ in that direction, leading through East's ♥A. When you win that trick repeat the maneuver.

It is really against the odds for East to hold ♥ A 10 9 x. In fact it would only occur perhaps one time in seven.

But there is no reason to go down once every seven times when you don't need to.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A K J 5
 ♥ A J 10 5
 ♦ A 6 4
 ♣ 8 3

♠ 10 9 2

♥ Q 7 3

♦ 9 8 7

♣ K 9 6 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 4

♥ K 8 6 2

♦ K Q J 3

♣ A 7 5

♠ 8 7 6 3

♥ 9 4

♦ 10 5 2

♣ Q J 10 4

West	North	East	South
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			
6♥ by East			
your winners.			

The 2♣ bid was Stayman, so you bid your ♥s.

Partner takes the direct approach and puts you in slam.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♣Q. South finds their best lead, exposing your ♣ loser right off the bat.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

If you can guess the ♥ finesse correctly you will make 7, discarding dummy's ♣ loser on the fourth ♦. But if you guess wrong they will immediately set you with a ♣ trick.

There is a better way - one that combines two chances. Win the ♣A. Then play your ♥A and ♥K. If the ♥Q happens to fall, pull the last trump and run

If the ♥Q **DOESN'T** fall, (she won't of course), switch to ♦s. On the fourth round of ♦s discard dummy's ♣, whether it is ruffed with the ♥Q or not.

If you knew to play the North for the ♥Q then you wouldn't need this improved plan.

But playing the deal as described will win whenever the ♥Q is doubleton, **OR** when the player with the protected ♥Q holds at least 3 ♦s.

Pretty good odds, better than the going rate for finesses, which is 50% off.

There was an alternate plan, just as good. After taking the two top trumps, run the ♠s, discarding two ♣s from your hand. As you see, either would have worked.